DELAWARE

The First State



The frost hadn't yet lifted from the Delaware River when Pieter Claessen pulled on his boots and made his way to the smokehouse. It was 1698, and the Swedish and Dutch settlements scattered along the banks of the Christina River had learned, through hard winters and harder lessons, that nothing from the hog could be wasted.

Pieter's wife, Margareta, had learned the technique from her mother—a woman who had crossed the Atlantic with nothing but a cast iron pot and the stubborn certainty that pork scraps, cornmeal, and buckwheat flour could be coaxed into something worth eating. The result was pannhaas—what the Germans settling nearby would call scrapple—a dense, spiced loaf of everything the butcher left behind: the snouts, the hearts, the liver, bound together with meal and fried hard in a pan until the outside crackled like autumn leaves underfoot.

For decades, scrapple was a farmhand's fuel-sliced thick and eaten plain beside a tin cup of coffee before the fields demanded your back. It fed the watermen who worked the Delaware Bay for oysters and the grain millers along the Brandywine Creek whose days started before the sun had any ambition.

It was somewhere in the early 1800s, in the bustle of Wilmington's morning market stalls, that a practical and unnamed genius—likely a vendor tired of selling scrapple and bread separately—pressed a fried slice between two thick cuts of bread with a smear of mustard and perhaps a runny egg. Farmers coming in from New Castle County, dockworkers from the Christina riverfront, and tannery workers from the Brandywine district all found themselves holding the same thing: a warm, salty, unapologetically humble sandwich that cost almost nothing and asked very little of the morning.

The Quaker-settled towns of Kent and Sussex counties adopted it eagerly. Church socials in Dover offered it alongside apple butter. Diners near Smyrna and Middletown kept it on hand for the men who drove produce north toward Philadelphia before dawn. The sandwich had no grand origin story, no celebrated chef, no wealthy patron—it belonged entirely to the people who needed it most and had the least time to sit down for breakfast.

Even now, the scrapple breakfast sandwich remains the quiet pride of the First State. You'll find it at roadside diners along Route 13, at fall festivals across Sussex County, and at the Apple Scrapple Festival in Bridgeville each October, a celebration that proves Delaware has never once been embarrassed by its thrift. Order it with a fried egg and sharp cheddar, and you are, without ceremony, eating three hundred years of history in your hands.

SCRAPPLE BREAKFAST SANDWICH

Crispy, creamy, salty, and cheesy, a scrapple breakfast sandwich is everything great about a Delaware morning in a single bite.

Yield: 1 sandwich

INGREDIENTS

- 2 slices pre-made scrapple (about ½ inch thick; recommended brands: Rapa, Habbersett, Kirby's)
- 1 egg, cooked how you like it (fried or scrambled works best)
- 1–2 slices American cheese or cheddar
- 1 sandwich roll (kaiser roll—most classic; English muffin; toasted bagel with butter; biscuit)
- Butter or oil, for frying
- Classic additions (optional): Ketchup, hot sauce, or apple butter (yep—sweet/savory magic).

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Fry the scrapple*: Heat a pan with a bit of butter or oil over medium heat. Fry scrapple slices until golden and crispy on both sides (3–4 minutes per side). Don't flip too early.
2. *Cook the egg*: In the same or separate pan, cook your egg to preference. A runny yolk makes a killer sandwich, but scrambled works great too.
3. *Toast the bread*: Lightly toast or warm your roll, bagel, or muffin. Optionally, butter the inside and toast on a skillet for extra flavor.
4. *Assemble*: Bottom bun → slice of cheese → scrapple → egg → another cheese slice if you're wild → ketchup or other sauce → top bun.
5. *Serve*: Enjoy hot with a cup of coffee or a glass of sweet tea for the regional vibe.

